

Q. What do you want from Pakistan?

A. We want them to hand over those Indian fugitives who have run away from here. They should try the perpetrators of Mumbai. A fair and transparent trial should be held, not a sham. The prosecution should be done properly. They should punish them. Only then will we be satisfied.

Q. Are you saying that Pakistani nationals who are involved be tried over there? Won't you try them here?

A. Yes, this can happen. The trial should be transparent. We have caught Ajmal Kasab. But there were others who were a part of the conspiracy. They should be caught and tried there. The authorities there should not let them go scot-free.

Q. Don't you want them to be brought here?

A. If they can hand them over to us, we will only be too glad. But if they don't, at least they should hand over those other criminals who have committed offences here, escaped the law and taken shelter there.

Q. But did you really expect Pakistan to do anything?

A. I hope that pressure will help Pakistan discharge its responsibility which it is obliged to do as a party to various international norms and decisions.

Q. You are saying that everyone is putting pressure, but the US is planning to triple its civilian aid.

A. I can't explain the conduct of other countries. This is a reality we have to live with.

Q. British Foreign Secretary David Miliband came here and disagreed with you on the Pakistan Government's support to terrorism.

A. I told him that we disagree with his perception.

Q. Pakistan says it wants a joint investigation.

A. I would ask the Pakistani leadership this question because President Zardari himself wanted international agencies to investigate Benazir Bhutto's assassination. I don't think any joint investigation will work.

Q. Do you think the international community will allow India to go in for a military option?

A. All options are open. I will only say that the appropriate option will be exercised at an appropriate time.

Q. Is Pakistan a failed state?

A. I will not use the specific word, but there are various centres of power in Pakistan and there is a lack of coordination.

Q. Your junior colleague E. Ahamed has said that we should snap all diplomatic ties with Israel.

A. A man has various identities. Ahamed is an important leader of his political party. He has just expressed his views.

Q. A.R. Antulay also gave a handle to Pakistan by questioning the things that happened in Mumbai.

A. Firstly, he did not give a handle to Pakistan. He merely explained his own doubts. Once the home minister replied

to the issue, and explained the situation, he was satisfied.

Q. All your ministers speak in different languages at some point of time. For instance, the home minister talked about curtailing visas, snapping off commercial relations. Didn't he speak on the issues concerning your ministry?

A. For him the question of options was theoretical. I have chosen not to spell out the options and this is a policy which I am going to adopt. If somebody theoretically explains these options, I don't think it is against the policies.

Q. Mr Mukherjee, the Left parties withdrew support to your Government, but do you think the Congress and Left can form a post-poll alliance to keep the NDA out?

A. It has been said that politics is the art of the possible. Therefore everything is possible.

Q. So will you be open to new coalition partners?

A. So far as the pre-elections coalition is concerned, those who are currently a part of the UPA Government are expected to stay. The post-election partners will depend on the numbers. But we will choose them without compromising the basic principles of the party.

Q. What issues will dominate in these elections? Will terrorism be a major one?

A. Performance, development and leadership will be the key issues in the upcoming polls.

Q. Leadership plays an important role, but questions are being raised about your statement about Rahul Gandhi being the candidate for the prime minister's post.

A. I was responding to the questions at the Pravasi Bharatiya Sammelan. Someone asked me why India has an aging leadership. I gave a number of examples, like that of Praful Mahanta,

Omar Abdullah, and I said Rajiv Gandhi became prime minister when he was 40 and then I said, who knows Rahul Gandhi may one day follow in the footsteps of his father.

Q. So you are not ruling out Manmohan Singh as the next prime minister.

A. Of course some of the UPA partners have stated that we will fight under the leadership of Prime Minister Manmohan Singh. Congress President Sonia Gandhi has also said that.

Q. So are you saying that the next elections will be fought under the leadership of Manmohan Singh and there is no doubt about that?

A. Yes, positively.

Q. What is the future of the omnipresent Pranab Mukherjee

A. I am reminded of a line from an old song, *Whatever will be, will be, the future is not ours to see.*

"PAKISTAN SHOULD HAND OVER INDIAN FUGITIVES AND MUST PUNISH THE MASTERMINDS OF MUMBAI ATTACKS."

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